AREA MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Area Manager Essentials — Day 3: Coach Managers to Improve Sales Conversations

Study guide · Self-study

Day 3: Coach Managers to Improve Sales Conversations

How to Use This Guide

This guide is for you, working on your own. You are an Area Manager responsible for sales performance and development across several stores, branches or business units. You do not run a single unit yourself. You lead the people who do.

Today is about one specific skill: coaching your unit managers on how they coach their teams. Not doing their job. Teaching them to do it better.

Read each section in order. Do the writing. The reflections and the "What Would You Say?" exercise ask you to put something on paper before you look at the model answers. Do that. Writing first is what makes the model answers useful instead of just agreeable.

The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you. The principle matters more than the exact wording. A short self-scoring exercise in the Upskill Challenge tells you where you stand.

One habit before you start: keep this guide open next to a real sales conversation you can observe this week, either a recorded call or a live one. You will use it in the Upskill Challenge.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know how to separate observed selling behavior from assumptions during a performance review with a unit manager, and how to use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) to give feedback on the manager's coaching.

Attitude: You will treat your unit managers as developers of people, not as reps you can correct yourself. When a rep struggles, your instinct shifts from "I will fix this" to "I will teach the manager to fix this."

Skill: You will be able to observe one coaching conversation, give specific feedback on the coaching behavior, agree a practice task, and set a measurable checkpoint.

Upskill: You will run a full coaching plan for a struggling manager's team independently: a rewritten discovery question, a value explanation, and a follow-up checkpoint tied to a number.

Separate What You Saw From What You Assume

Good coaching starts with evidence. Most area reviews fail here. A manager reports a drop in conversion, and the room fills with explanations: "the team is complacent," "the new hires aren't trying," "the market changed." None of these is something anyone saw. They are stories about character or conditions.

Your job is to describe behavior you actually observed. That means sitting in on real conversations, listening to recorded sales calls, or watching a counter interaction. Only then can you say what a manager's team actually does with a client.

The buyer psychology matters here too. A client forms an impression of your whole area from one conversation. If a seller opens with a list of features before asking a single question, the client feels processed, not helped. You cannot see that in a conversion number. You can only see it by listening.

On Day 2 you compared results with context. Today you go one level deeper: the behavior inside the conversation that produces those results.

Here is the discipline. For each unit manager, write down two columns: what I observed, and what I assume. Anything that could not survive being played back on a recording belongs in the second column.

Reflection: Think of your most recent performance conversation with a unit manager. Name one thing you said that was an assumption, not an observation. Write it down. Then write the observable behavior you would need to see to make the same point honestly.

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake is to lead with the number and work backward to a behavior that fits it. Start with behavior and let the number confirm or challenge it.

Ask Diagnostic Questions Before You Give Answers

When you sit with a unit manager to review their team's selling, resist the urge to supply the fix. Ask first. A manager who reaches the diagnosis themselves is far more likely to act on it, because it is theirs. A manager you have corrected will comply in the room and drift afterward.

The buyer psychology is the same one you are coaching. A seller who asks questions learns the client's real need. A seller who opens with a feature list guesses. The same is true of you and your manager. Ask what happened, what they noticed, what they would try. Then wait.

This is where the instinct to rescue the conversation does real damage. Most people, managers included, find even a few seconds of silence uncomfortable and fill it. If you fill the silence with your own answer, you hand the manager an easier question and lose the revealing one. Let them sit with it.

Useful diagnostic questions:

"What did you notice in that conversation before the client mentioned price?"

"What was the client trying to solve, in their words?"

"What did the seller recommend, and how did that connect to what the client said they needed?"

"Where in the conversation did the client's energy change?"

Reflection: Write one diagnostic question that fits your area's most common selling problem. Keep it to one sentence.

> **NOTES**
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> If your manager answers a question with a story about the market, ask a second question about a specific conversation. Specific beats general every time.

Give Feedback on Behavior, Not Character

Your managers will hear feedback about their coaching as criticism of them personally unless you are careful. That is human. Feedback that sounds like a verdict on who someone is triggers defense; feedback about a specific moment is far easier to hear and act on.

Specific feedback is also less threatening because it is checkable. "You are not a strong coach" invites an argument. "In yesterday's session, you told Sam what to say before asking what he noticed" invites a conversation about one moment that both of you can picture.

This is the logic behind SBI, a feedback model from the Center for Creative Leadership. You describe the specific Situation, the observable Behavior and its Impact. This course adds one step to the original model: have the person practice. Here is how it sounds with a unit manager. "Yesterday, in your coaching session with Sam (Situation), you answered the objection for him instead of asking what he had tried (Behavior). He stopped contributing after that and the conversation turned into you talking to the rep (Impact). What were you aiming for there?"

Notice what the SBI does and does not do. It states facts, it names the impact on the person being coached, and it ends with an open question. It does not label the manager lazy or controlling. That is what makes honest diagnosis possible. If your feedback is about character, your managers will hide their real coaching from you. If it is about behavior, they will invite you in.

Practice example: You observe a unit manager, Priya, coaching a seller on a lost deal. The seller says the client found the price too high. Priya replies, "Just offer a five percent reduction next time." You speak to Priya privately. "In the session with Daniel this morning, you suggested a reduction as the first response to a price concern. Daniel wrote it down, so he will likely do that with the next client too. It solves this one deal and leaves the underlying objection untouched. What would help you test whether the objection was really about price?" Priya says she does not know. You say, "Try asking him what the client compared your offer to. Want to rehearse that question with me now?" You then have Priya practice asking it, and agree to observe her next session. That is SBI with the practice step included.

Reflection: Rewrite one piece of feedback you recently gave a manager so that it contains a Situation, a Behavior and an Impact, and a practice step. Read it aloud. Does it sound like a fact or a verdict?

> **NOTES**
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> Remove every adjective about the person. Keep every noun about the moment.

Watch Feature-Heavy Presentations Overload the Buyer

Your managers' sellers lose deals in a predictable place: the presentation. When a seller is nervous or unsure of the client's need, the instinct is to say everything. Every feature, every specification, every option. The seller feels thorough. The client feels buried.

The buyer psychology is working against the seller here. A client listening to a wall of features has to hold too many comparisons in mind at once. Research on choice overload shows that more options

can leave people less able to decide, not more (Iyengar and Lepper, 2000). And when information is hard to process, it creates strain, and strained buyers become guarded rather than persuaded. The seller's thoroughness reads to the client as noise.

The fix is relevance. A recommendation tied to something the client actually said feels like help. The same product described in general terms feels like a pitch. This is why the discovery question matters so much: it produces the material that makes the presentation specific.

Your coaching point for unit managers is not "present less." It is "present what the client asked for." Watch for a presentation where the seller lists a feature the client never mentioned. That is the moment to coach.

Practice example: A seller opens a meeting with a logistics client by listing twelve software features. The client had said, two minutes earlier, that dispatch errors were costing them hours every week. The manager, listening, notes the moment. In the coaching session afterward, they ask the seller, "What did the client say mattered most?" The seller recalls the dispatch errors. The manager asks, "If you had to name only what removes that problem, what would you say?" The seller names two features. The manager says, "Next time, say those two and ask which one they want to see first." At the next call, the seller's opening is two sentences long and the client asks a question. That is a relevance shift you can observe.

Reflection: Find one recent sales call in your area where the seller listed features the client never asked about. Write the one sentence the seller should have led with instead.

> **NOTES**
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> Coach relevance with a question, not a correction. "Which of those did the client ask for?" does more than "you overloaded them."

Why Specific Coaching Opens Honest Conversations

Put the last two ideas together and you have the argument for how you spend your time. A judgment about a manager's ability makes them defensive, and defensive managers present their best sessions to you and hide the rest. Behavioral feedback, delivered with evidence and a practice step, lowers the stakes enough that a manager will show you the real work. Honest diagnosis requires that.

The same principle explains why buyers open up to sellers who ask and listen rather than sellers who assert. A client who feels judged for their current setup defends it. A client who feels understood explains what is actually broken. Your managers are clients of your coaching. The psychology runs in the same direction.

So sequence your coaching like a good sales call. Ask what they noticed. Reflect back what you heard. Describe the specific behavior. Agree one practice task. Set a checkpoint with a measurable commitment. One behavior, not five. A manager working on one thing for two weeks changes more than a manager given a list.

Reflection: Which of your unit managers currently treats your coaching as judgment rather than help? Write one thing you could change about how you deliver it.

> **NOTES**
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> If a manager gives you a polished account of their coaching, they may be performing for you. Ask to watch their next coaching session live.

Apply It in Your Role

Across branches, your influence flows in three directions.

To your unit managers: observe one of their coaching conversations, give SBI feedback on the coaching behavior, agree one practice task, and set a checkpoint. Track whether coaching happens consistently across teams, not only in the unit with the best numbers. A manager who coaches one favorite closely and ignores the rest is producing a team that will drift.

To your own manager: ask to be observed coaching your unit managers, and ask for SBI feedback in return. You are modeling the behavior you want them to use. Report coaching quality, not just results, in your own updates.

To regional or head office: ask about coaching quality in reviews, not only conversion and revenue. If the people above you only ever ask about numbers, your managers learn that coaching does not count. Request protected time to observe real conversations. Share what strong coaching looks like across the area.

The risk of stepping in yourself is real. When a rep fumbles a deal and you are in the room, fixing it feels efficient. It is not. You coach the rep, and you teach the manager that their coaching is optional.

No area role yet? Do the same task with a business you know well (a past employer or a chain you buy from), or with the practice examples in this guide.

What Would You Say?

Write your answers before you read the Model Answers. This is the practice that makes the rest stick.

Situation 1. You observe a unit manager, Marcus, coaching a seller who lost a deal at the negotiation stage. Marcus tells the seller, "Next time, just hold firm and don't give anything away." The seller nods. What do you say to Marcus afterward?

Situation 2. A unit manager in your area tells you, "My team's conversion is down and I don't know why. I've told them to try harder." What diagnostic question do you ask first?

Situation 3. During a review, you notice that a manager's coaching sessions cover winning new sales but never how sellers handle existing clients' service problems. Write your SBI feedback in full, including the practice step and the checkpoint.

Situation 4. A seller in one of your branches opened a client meeting with fourteen product features and lost the client's attention. You want the manager to coach this without taking over. What do you ask the manager to do, and what do you agree to check?

Key Takeaways

- Your job is to develop managers who develop sellers, not to coach sellers yourself.
- Coach the coaching. Watch how the manager coaches, and give feedback on that behavior.
- Separate observed behavior from assumption before any performance conversation. If it would not survive a recording, it is a story.
- Use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) and finish with a practice step. Three parts and a practice: that is the whole model.
- Ask diagnostic questions and then wait. Filling the silence costs you the manager's own diagnosis.
- Specific feedback about one moment is easier to hear than a judgment about character, which is exactly why it produces honest conversations.
- A feature-heavy presentation overloads the buyer. Coach sellers to recommend what the client actually asked for.
- Agree one practice task and one measurable checkpoint. One behavior at a time.

Quiz

Answer the five questions. Choose one option for each. Write your answers down before you check the key.

1. Which statement is an observation rather than an assumption?

   A. The team has become complacent since the reorg.

   B. In this morning's call, the seller named four features before asking the client a question.

   C. The new hires are not trying hard enough.

   D. The market has gotten tougher this quarter.

2. What are the parts of SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact)?

   A. Situation, Benefit, Insight, then a target.

   B. Story, Belief, Intention, then a warning.

   C. Situation, Behavior, Impact, then have the person practice.

   D. Strength, Blind spot, Improvement, then a review.

3. You ask a unit manager what they noticed in their coaching session. They go quiet. What should you do?

   A. Fill the silence with your own theory.

   B. Move on to the next topic.

   C. Wait, and let them answer.

   D. Tell them what they did wrong.

4. A seller has just spent ten minutes listing product features the client never asked about. Based on the psychology in this guide, why did this lose the client?

   A. The features were inaccurate.

   B. The seller spoke too quietly.

   C. The client needed more options to choose from.

   D. Too many options and unfiltered detail create strain, and nothing was tied to what the client actually said they needed.

5. You want a unit manager to change one coaching behavior. What is the best sequence?

   A. Give the manager a full list of everything to improve at once, then review next quarter.

   B. Describe the specific behavior, have them practice it, and set a checkpoint on one agreed task.

   C. Coach the reps yourself so the manager can see how it is done.

   D. Tell the manager to "be a better coach" and check back later.

Upskill Challenge

Complete this on the job, using a real sales conversation, before Day 5. You are not taking over the manager's role; you are observing and coaching the manager.

No area role yet? Observe any manager coaching or giving feedback (at work, in a team you belong to, or in a recorded training video) and complete the plan for that manager.

Step 1. Choose a unit manager and one upcoming coaching conversation they will have with a seller. Choose a manager you have not observed closely before, not just your strongest one.

Step 2. Observe the conversation. Take notes in two columns: observed behavior, and your assumptions. Keep the assumptions out of the feedback.

Step 3. Give the manager SBI feedback on their coaching behavior, not the rep's sales skill. Include the practice step.

Step 4. Agree one practice task and one measurable checkpoint with the manager. Write both down in their words.

Step 5. Rewrite one discovery question the seller used, so it asks about the client's real need instead of confirming a feature.

Step 6. Write one value explanation the seller could have used, tied to something the client actually said.

Step 7. Complete the coaching plan below for the manager.

Manager:

What I observed (behavior):

What I assumed (kept out of feedback):

My SBI feedback on the coaching:

Practice task agreed:

Measurable checkpoint:

Date of checkpoint: ____

Rewritten discovery question:

Value explanation, tied to a stated need:

Self-score your coaching on each item from 1 (did not do) to 5 (did well). Write the score on the line.

☐ Feedback described a specific moment, not character: ____

☐ All three SBI parts present, plus practice: ____

☐ Practice task is one behavior, not a list: ____

☐ Checkpoint is measurable and dated: ____

☐ I did not coach the seller directly: ____

Total: ____

> **NOTES**
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> The goal is real information, not confirmation of what you already assumed. If you find yourself correcting the seller in the room, stop and move the correction into the manager's coaching session afterward.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your wording should sound like you. Read the principle behind each.

Situation 1. "Marcus, in the session with the seller just now, you told them to hold firm and give nothing away. They nodded and wrote it down, so they will likely do that next time too, whether or not the objection was really about price. What would help you test what the client was actually comparing?" Then have Marcus practice the question with you. Why it works: it names the specific behavior, states the impact on the seller, and ends with an open question rather than a verdict. The practice step makes it a skill, not a lecture.

Situation 2. "Pick one conversation from this week where a client said no. What did the seller do before the objection came up?" Why it works: "try harder" is a character instruction with no behavior attached. Your question moves the manager toward one real conversation where behavior can be observed. If the manager answers with a general story about the market, ask a second question about a specific call.

Situation 3. "In the last three coaching sessions you ran with your team (Situation), you covered converting leads and closing on the spot, and no session touched how a seller handles an existing client's service problem (Behavior). Those clients are the ones most likely to renew, and when one leaves we cannot see why from the numbers alone; that gap lands on your retention, not just on the seller's (Impact). What would you need to see to give one session to service-and-renewal conversations this month? Would the week of the eighth or the week of the fifteenth suit your calendar better?" Then have the manager rehearse their opening question for that session with you,

and agree to review the recording of it together. Why it works: it names a specific situation, states the behavior as a gap in coverage rather than a flaw in the manager, ties the impact to a result the manager owns, and ends with an open question and a genuine choice that includes dates, never a yes/no close. The practice step and the shared recording make the follow-up concrete.

Situation 4. Ask the manager: "Which of those fourteen features did the client ask for?" Let them answer. Then agree: "In your next two reviews with that seller, ask what the client said mattered most before discussing what the seller presented. I will listen to the next recorded call with you on the twelfth and we will check whether the opening two minutes are tied to a stated need." Why it works: you are coaching the manager's coaching, you agree one behavior, and you set a measurable checkpoint without taking the seller's development away from the manager.

Reflection on self-scoring: any item below 3 is your next practice focus. A low score is information, not failure.

Quiz answers:

1. B. It describes a specific, checkable moment in a real conversation; the others are stories about character or conditions.

2. C. SBI is Situation, Behavior, Impact, and then the person practices; it is not complete without the practice step.

3. C. Waiting lets the manager reach the diagnosis themselves, which makes them far more likely to act on it.

4. D. Unfiltered detail creates strain and guardedness, and relevance requires a recommendation tied to what the client said they needed.

5. B. One specific behavior with practice and a measurable checkpoint beats a list, a vague verdict, or taking the rep away from the manager.

References

Center for Creative Leadership (CCL). SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact).

Iyengar, S. S., & Lepper, M. R. (2000). When choice is demotivating: Can one desire too much of a good thing? Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 995–1006.